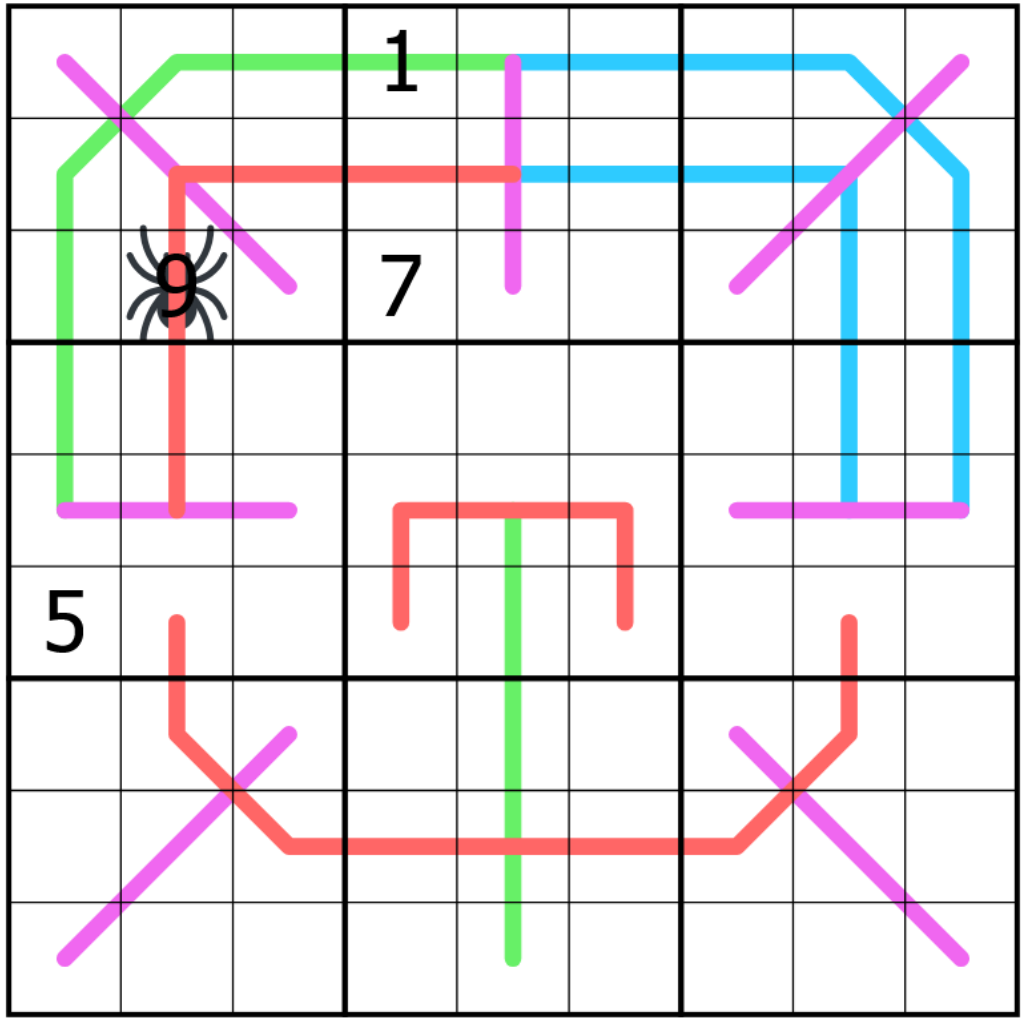
SPIDER-MAN SUDOKU

Cracking the Cryptic – Patreon reward, May 2026

Each sudoku will require you to bring forward a spider cell (9) from the previous puzzle – put it in the same location in the next grid. When you reach the last puzzle, the solution message will tell you how to derive the key phrase.

Each page contains text relating to Spider-Man's story as derived from various movies. This text is effectively all spoilers! Don't read it if you think you might watch the movies later. Unless you think it might help you with the sudoku hunt.

1. GREEN GOBLIN



Normal sudoku rules apply. Neighbouring digits on a green line have a difference of at least 5. Neighbouring digits on a red line include one odd and one even digit. Digits on a purple line are a consecutive sequence, in any order. Box borders divide a blue line into segments with the same sum.

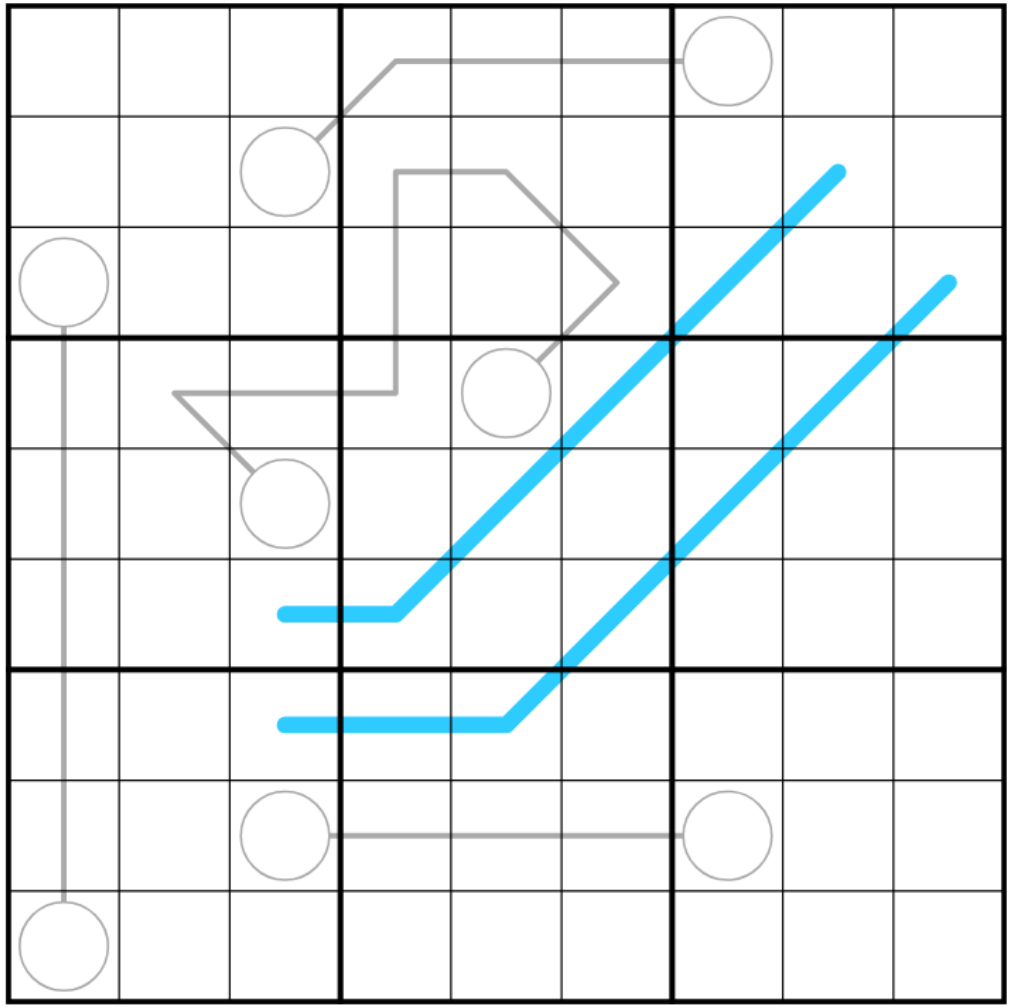
In the Spider-verse everything happens for a reason, it seems. The radioactive spider that bit Peter Parker can hardly have known it was choosing the perfect victim. Someone who was intelligent, but shy and awkward, and who would never have cast himself as a superhero. Yet here he is, endowed with superhuman strength, speed, agility, and also able to cling to vertical surfaces and spin webs.

Because he is still coming to terms with these strange powers, Peter struggles to cope for a while. In a sense, he must totally reinvent himself as he invents his new persona too. Thus he spins a massive web of self-identity, encompassing many strands of different types. Some involve differences with his past, some provide balance and some form sequences towards his future. Yesterday's man takes the first steps towards tomorrow's hero.

So when Peter's uncle is killed by a thief, he sets off in pursuit. Peter, as Spider-Man, chases the criminal, who ultimately falls off a building. Involved with his feelings, Spider-Man is hardly ready to deal with the Green Goblin, who is coming after all who are near and dear to him. Despite saving both his friend Mary-Jane and some innocent children, Spider-Man is savaged by the Green Goblin, who seems entirely unhinged. Even in his brutalised state, Spider-Man has a glimmer of his spider-sense to warn him that the Green Goblin's glider is about to impale him. Rather than spearing Spider-Man, the glider sends its creator to his death!

https://sudokupad.app/keotxxptz7

2. DR OCTOPUS



Normal sudoku rules apply. Bring forward the 9 from nearest the centre of the 'web' in the last puzzle. Box borders divide a blue line into segments with an equal sum. Digits on a grey line have the same sum as the two circles on the end of a line.

Crime-fighting and living a normal life are hard to balance. Love, rent, secrets, studies and work are making things complicated. In truth, Peter is beginning to think that the Spider-Man identity is a burden. Mary-Jane tires of his secrets and gets engaged to a rival. But Peter cannot suppress his heroic side, and saves a child. Even though his powers are fading, he feels he must don the costume again. Dr Octavius, his friend, is about to change the narrative, however.

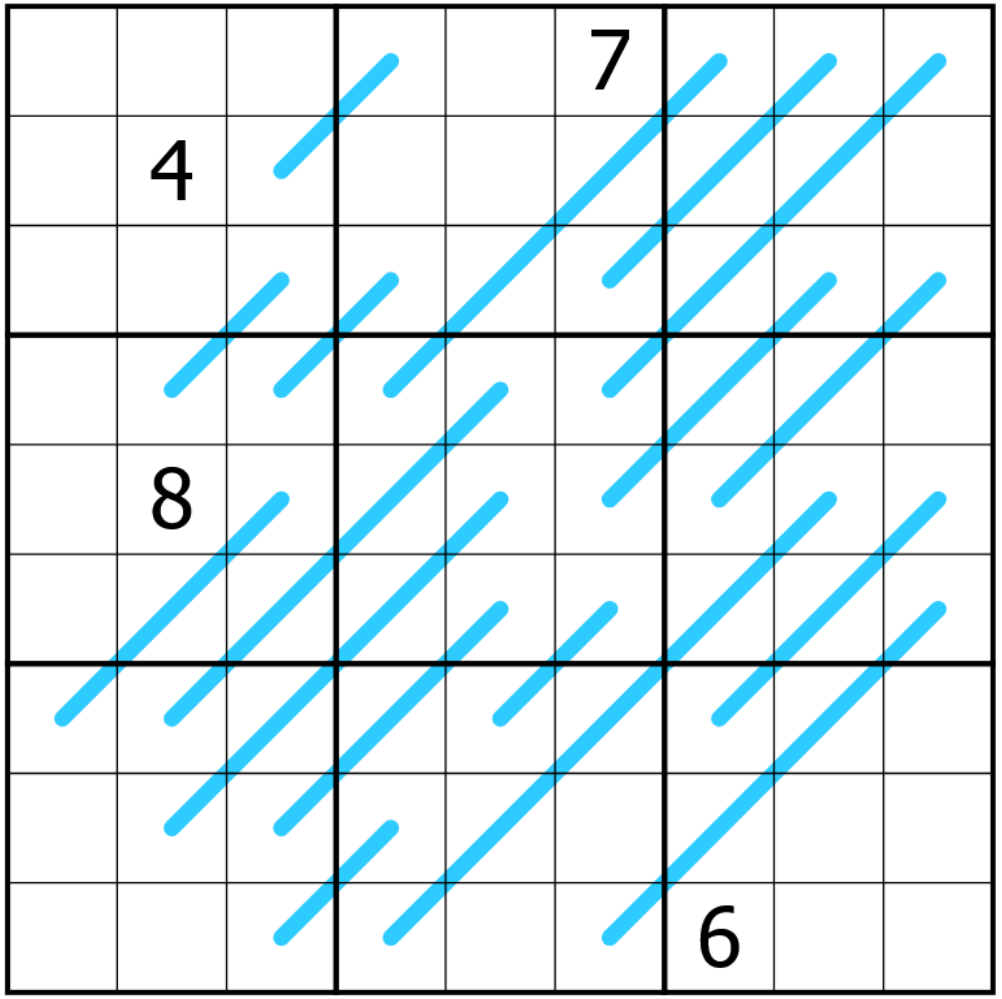
Using fusion power and AI, a harness with tentacles becomes attached to Dr Octavius's body. Part-man, part-machine, he is now a dangerous enemy.

Tritium is required to fuel the machine. Harry, Peter's former friend, promises it if Spider-Man is brought to him. Eagerly, Octavius agrees to do this.

When he finds Peter and Mary-Jane together, he swoops. Abducting Mary-Jane, he demands that Peter lead him to Spider-Man. This leads to a fight between Spider-Man and Dr Octavius. Even though he saves many lives in the fight, Spider-Man is delivered to Harry. Revealing Spider-Man's true identity, Harry is stunned. Soon he agrees to help save Mary-Jane. Peter unmasks himself to convince Octavius to prevent mass destruction. Octavius comes round and submerges the machine, at the cost of his own life. Under no illusion about Spider-Man's identity, Mary-Jane cannot deny her feelings. To that end, she misses her own wedding to be with Peter.

https://sudokupad.app/cjio5asyh7

3. SANDMAN



Normal sudoku rules apply. Bring the 9 from box 3 in the last puzzle into this one. Box borders divide a blue line into segments with the same sum.

Don't always assume that a superhero is naturally confident. Often they may be battling demons. What if that demon was extra-terrestrial? Now Peter's Spider-suit has been invaded by an aggressive symbiote.

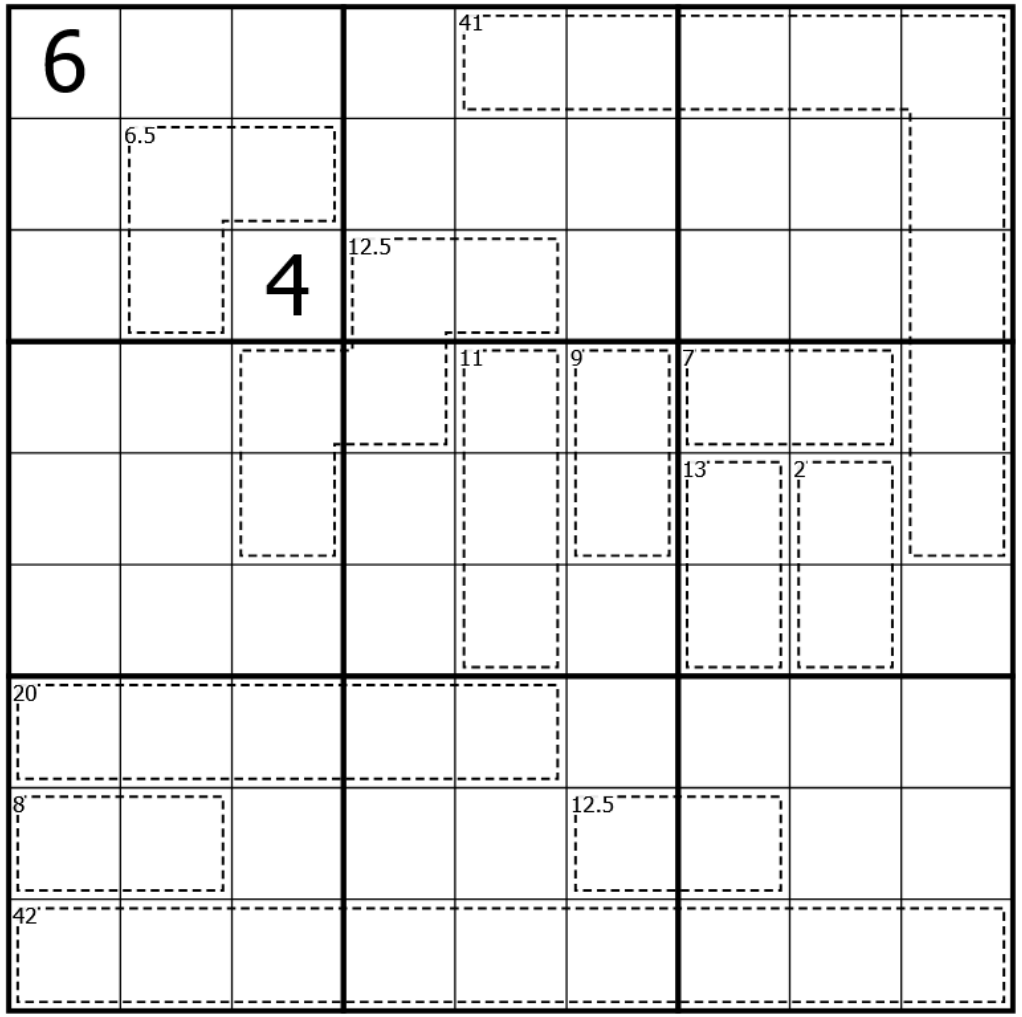
Convict Flint Marko has tried to visit his wife and sick daughter. As police pursue him, he falls into a particle accelerator. Marko becomes Sandman, able to dissolve into sand or reintegrate. Escaping is effectively his super-power.

The symbiote makes Spider-Man more powerful than before. However Peter also becomes more arrogant. Even Mary-Jane feels disconnected from him.

Real power sometimes stems from the brain. As Spider-Man battles Sandman in a subway station, he realises that water weakens him. Intelligently, he turns on a pipe to flood the station. Now Sandman is dissolved into mud and washed away.

https://sudokupad.app/1mmnsdm4ay

4. VENOM



Normal sudoku rules apply. The 9 from box 8 in the previous puzzle must be brought into this grid. One cell in each row, column and 3x3 box is a halver, and its value is half its digit. No two halvers contain the same digit. Digits do not repeat in cages, which show the sum of their values.

Arrogance is unattractive. Not realising this, Peter tries to make Mary-Jane jealous. During a fight, Peter accidentally hits Mary-Jane.

When he realises what the symbiote is doing to him, he is scared. As he hides in a bell tower, he realises that the sound of the bell weakens the symbiote. Sonic waves are its weakness! Hearing the bell repeatedly, the symbiote becomes detached. Eddie Brock witnesses this. Deciding to act as the alien's new host, he becomes Venom.

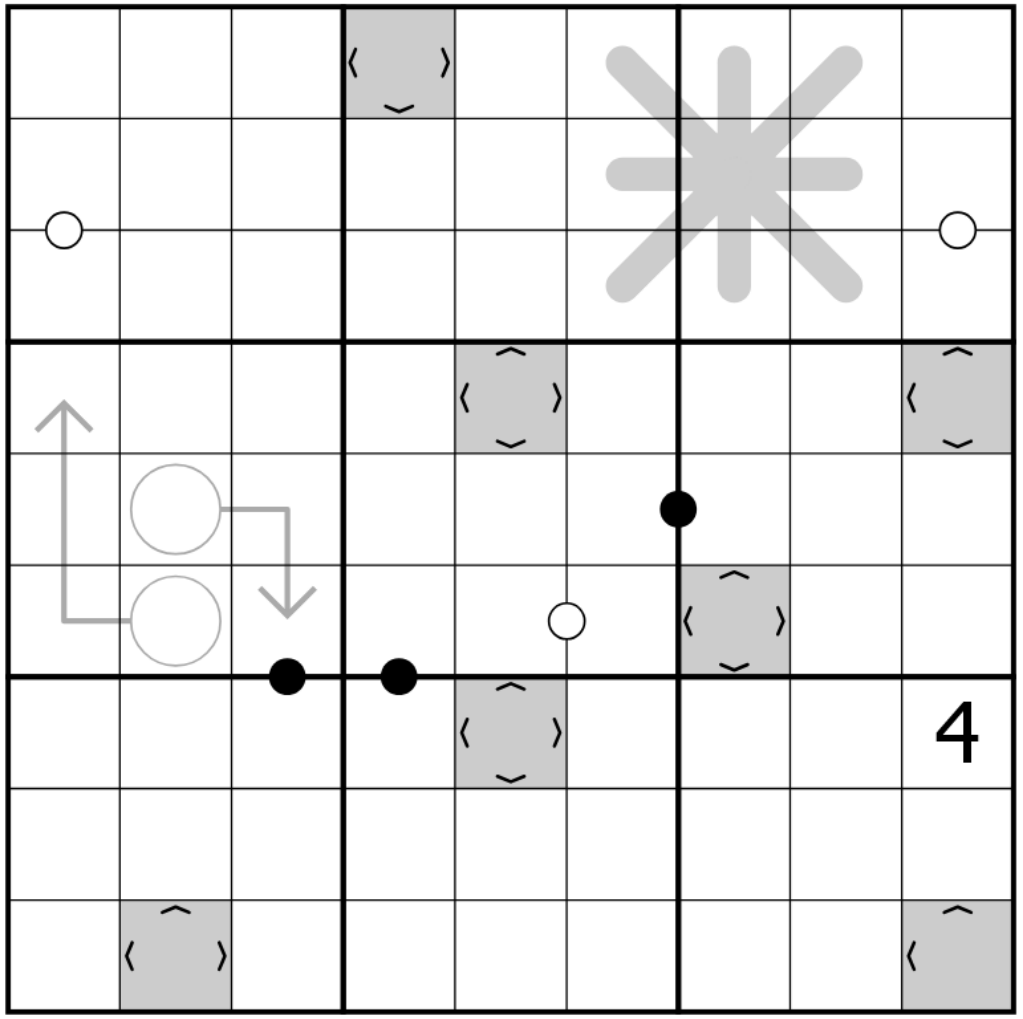
The Daily Bugle was Eddie's employer. He had been faking photos to incriminate Spider-Man. Eventually Peter had exposed him.

Spider-Man is attacked by Sandman and Venom together. Peter is captured when he tries to free Mary-Jane from them. In dire need, Peter gets help from his frenemy Harry. Disastrously, Harry is struck by his own glider. Eddie is now half-man and half-symbiote. Remembering the symbiote's reaction to noise, Peter uses the sound of metal pipes to weaken and detach it.

Out of desperation, Venom rushes at the symbiote as Peter is destroying it and suffers the same fate. Uncle Ben had been killed by Marko, but it was an accident, he explains. Tolerantly, Peter allows Sandman to escape.

https://sudokupad.app/2ytdyee4g4

5. LIZARD



Normal sudoku rules apply. Bring forward the digit 9 from box 7 in the last puzzle. For each of the following rules, no digit can be used twice in the marked cells (eg if there is a 9 in r1c4, there cannot be a 9 in another fortress cell):

On a black dot, one digit is double the other; on a white dot, there are consecutive digits; a grey fortress cell is greater than each cell it neighbours orthogonally; on a thermo, digits increase from the bulb (r2c7 is the common bulb); digits on an arrow sum to the digits in the attached circle.

Ordinary people would struggle to comprehend the struggles that superheroes have. Understanding more about these conflicts might surprise them. There is a lot going on behind the mask!

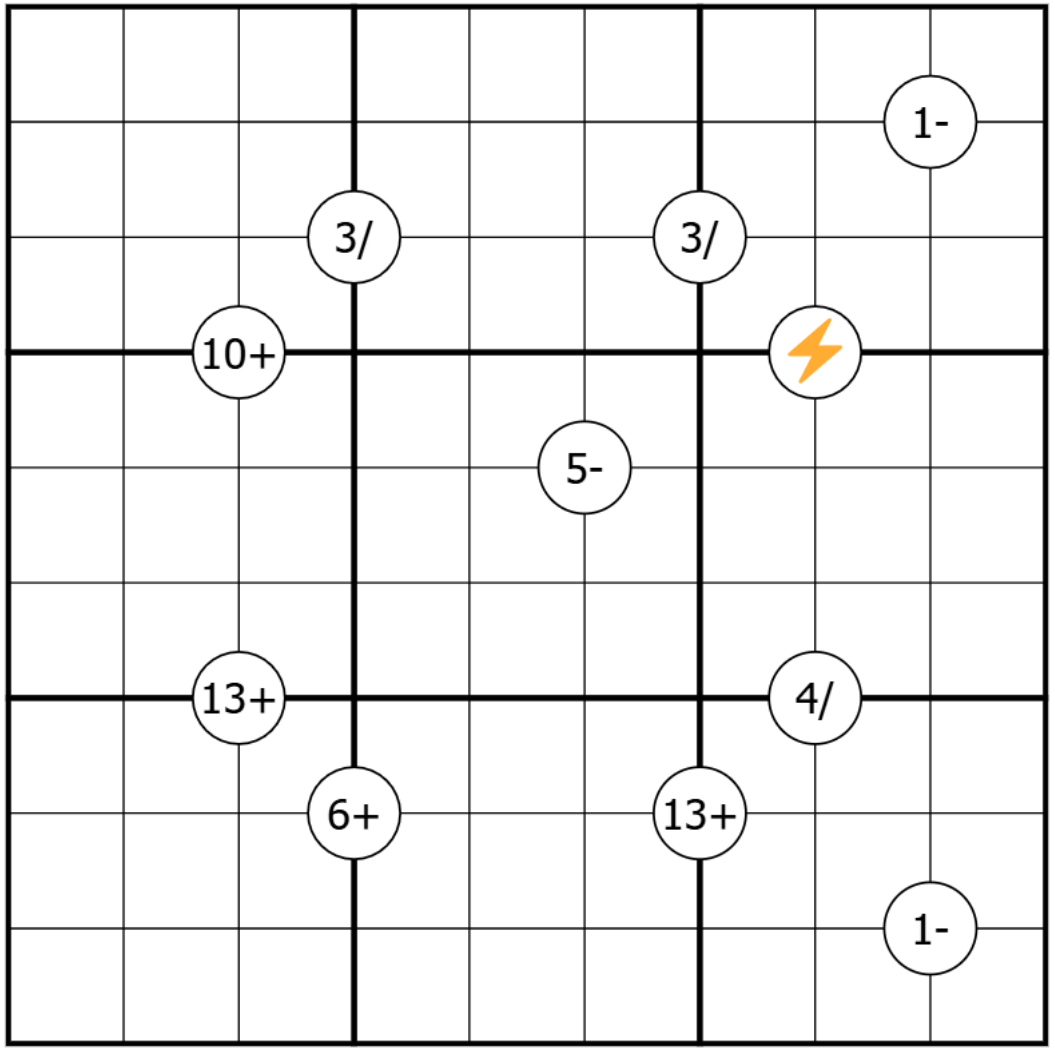
Curt Connors is researching cross-species genetics. As he begins trials to re-grow limbs using lizard DNA, he has professional qualms. More urgency results when he is fired by his boss, who plans to test the new serum on injured veterans. Even though he is nervous about the possible effects, Connors tries the serum on himself as he is an amputee.

Then he turns into a lizard-like monster. He starts attacking people, and Spider-Man has to intervene to save them. Endeavouring to stop the trouble without knowing its exact cause, the police pursue both the Lizard and Spider-Man.

Spider-Man discovers Connors' makeshift lab. Unique at the moment, the Lizard is planning to infect the whole city to turn everyone else into lizard monsters too. Next, Spider-Man is able to release an antidote developed by Gwen Stacy, protecting the city and curing the Lizard, as the sun rises.

https://sudokupad.app/uis9t4hsmi

6. ELECTRO



Normal sudoku rules apply. The digit 9 from a thermo in the last puzzle must be brought into this puzzle. Two cells diagonally connected across a circle must be able to achieve the number in the circle by applying the operation in the circle. The ⚡ symbol represents a repeat of another circle in the puzzle.

As all superheroes know, with great power comes great responsibility. Not all of us can mathematically understand how that power can be safely wielded. Decisions have consequences.

Depressed that he has a genetic illness, Harry Osborn infers that Spider-Man's blood could save him. Realising that Peter 'knows' Spider-Man, Harry asks him for help. If he got Spider-Man's blood, it might cause a dangerous mutation. Enraged by Spider-Man's refusal to help, Harry forms a new plan. Donald Menken has framed Harry for covering up an accident, and ousted him from the Oscorp corporation.

Unaware of what has happened to him, Max Dillon, the accident victim, walks into Times Square. Power outages result, as he has been mutated into Electro by a tank of genetically-engineered electric eels.

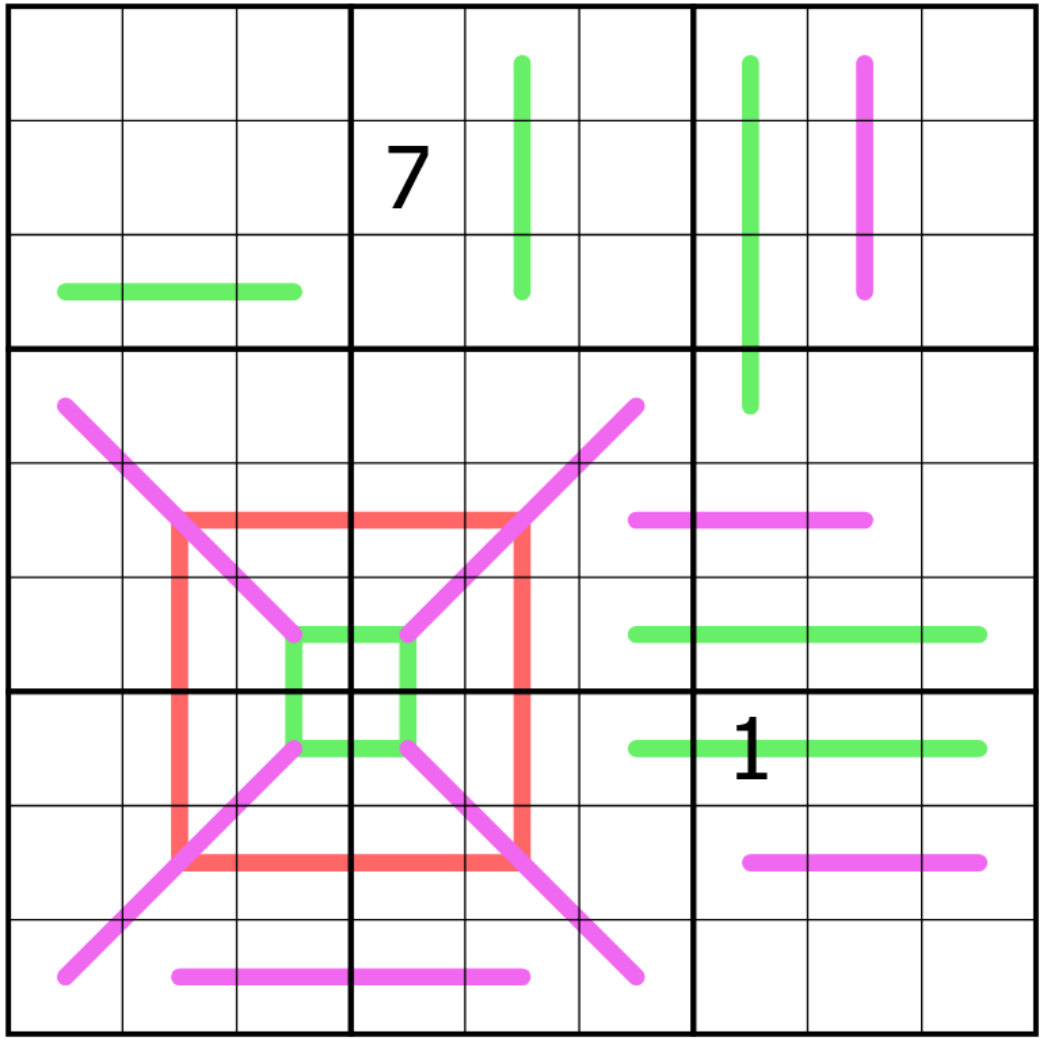
As Electro gets Harry back into Oscorp, Harry forces Menken to inject him with venom from genetically mutated spiders. Left alone, he mutates into a goblin-like being. Later he dons an armoured suit that can heal his body.

There is an outage at a power station, Peter discovers. He arrives to find Electro responsible. Electro is overloaded with electricity and destroyed.

Realising that Peter is Spider-Man, Harry decides to kill him. After Electro was dispatched, Harry had arrived with loads of weapons. In the fighting, Gwen falls to her death. Now Peter, having dealt with Harry, decides to end his Spider-Man career.

https://sudokupad.app/ln5kdxq3ql

7. THE RHINO



Normal sudoku rules apply. The 9 from box 4 must be brought forward from the previous puzzle into this puzzle.
Adjacent digits on a red line include one odd and one even digit. A purple line contains a sequence of consecutive digits, in any order. On a green line, adjacent digits have a difference of at least 5.

Alexei Sytsevich is a Russian criminal previously caught by Spider-Man. Now he will become the latest villain to benefit from Oscorp technology. Decked out in an electro-mechanical suit of armour, he becomes The Rhino.

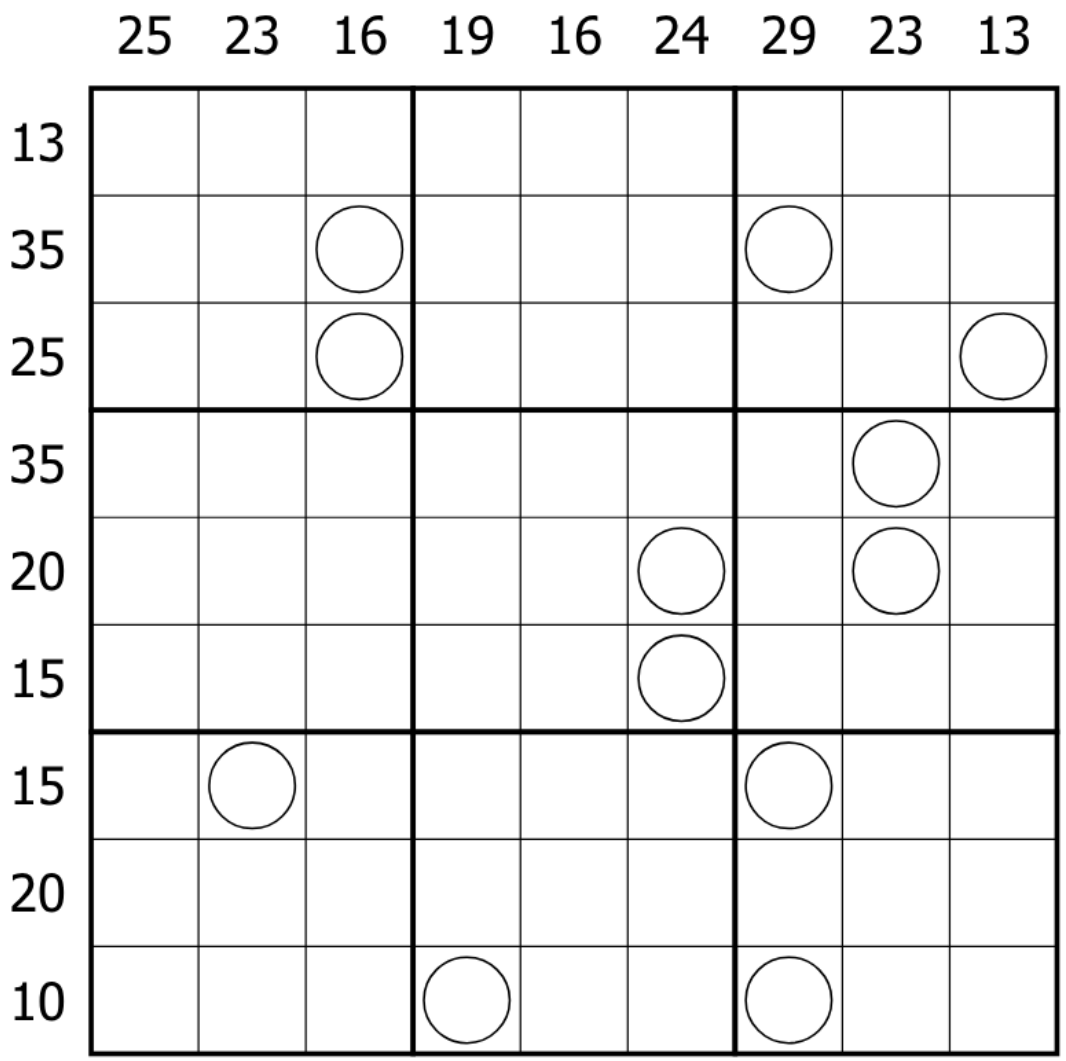
In Peter's world, things are a web of difficulties. The death of Gwen has rocked him, of course. Spider-Man is the least of his concerns. Yet some inner part of his being retains the superhero instinct.

Before she died, Gwen graduated and gave a speech. It urges everyone listening to retain hope. This is just what Peter needs to hear again. Spider-Man is resurrected. You can probably guess the rest ...

Spider-Man turns up in New York where The Rhino is causing havoc. Police are failing to have any effect on his armour plating. Incredibly a little boy in a Spider-Man suit confronts The Rhino. Despite his youth, he is brave and believes in Spider-Man. Eventually, just before The Rhino attacks, Spider-Man arrives and ushers the boy back to his mother. Running straight at Spider-Man, The Rhino is unprepared when he swings into action ...

https://sudokupad.app/1m7knd5vwr

8. KINGPIN



Normal sudoku rules apply. Bring forward the 9 from nearest the centre of the web in the last puzzle. A digit in a circle is: on a loop; counts how many of the (up to 9) touching cells (including itself) are on the loop; says how many times its digit appears in circles. The loop can touch itself diagonally but not orthogonally. A number outside the grid sums the digits on the loop in that row/column.

Can it be that parallel universes exist? Let's imagine one in which Peter Parker, as Spider-Man, is killed. If only someone else had recently been bitten by a radioactive spider! Miles Morales is our man, or teen. Because he was on hand at Peter's death, he inherits a flash drive that could save the city. Even in this parallel universe, it's only the city that is threatened, not the world. Disastrously, Miles damages the flash drive while trying to become Spider-Man.

Up pops another Spider-Man from a parallel universe. Peter Parker, for it is he, helps Miles construct a new flash drive.

They meet a new and diverse Dr Octopus. Her threats drive them into a forest. Except that here they are saved by a Spider-Woman, who is Gwen Stacy from another dimension!

Somehow, even more Spider-people have slipped into this universe from others. Prowler was an evil identity assumed by Miles's uncle, but he gets killed by Kingpin, who is leading the criminals and trying to make his universe-linking collider technology work. One of the problems with his machine is that it has brought all these Spider-people here! Unless our heroes can destroy the collider, the whole city is in peril. Then Peter nobly sacrifices himself, granting Miles a path to success.

And Miles takes it! Getting away from his restraints, he makes a new Spider-suit. Aunt May helps him, as she has helped all incarnations of Spider-Man throughout the dramas. In a final battle, Miles throws Kingpin at the machine and destroys it. Now the city is saved and Miles is reconciled with his father, a police chief who doubted Spider-Man.

https://sudokupad.app/wy3dbevk1t

IF YOU CAN DEFEAT ALL YOUR ENEMIES...

The key phrase (5 words) is obtained by using the clues revealed by successfully solving the last sudoku.

Click on this link to enter the solution key:

https://tinyurl.com/SpiderManSudoku

Enter by 4pm UK time on 20th May for the chance to win a prize, which will be a collaboration solve with Simon.

Good luck!

Simon & Mark